

Upside Down Kingdom 2

Week 2 — 10/6/26

Matthew 5:17–20

Beatitudes
5:3–12

3 Hope Images
5:13–16

Antitheses
5:17–48

Righteous Practices
6:1–20

Parallel Discourses
6:21–7:12

3 Warning Images
7:13–27

REVIEW OF LAST WEEK

- Promise of persecution in vv. 11–12 contextualizes this discussion with OT prophets: heralds and reinforcers of the covenant
- By extension, then, Jesus’s disciples are likewise the heralds of this new-covenant message
- Salt & light metaphors evoke the biblical hope of new-covenant era: God will return, bring comfort, and reveal glory throughout the world
- Christian conduct (innate “salty”/Christlike nature in our deeds, letting light shine for God) will be the focus of the rest of the Sermon

PASSAGE OF THE WEEK (NET)

a	17	Do not think that I have come to abolish the law or the prophets. I have not come to abolish these things but to fulfill them.
b	18	I tell you the truth,
c		until heaven and earth pass away
b'		not the smallest letter or stroke of a letter will pass from the law
a		until everything takes place.
b	19	So anyone who breaks one of the least of these commands
c		and teaches others to do so
a'		will be called least in the kingdom of heaven,
b'		but whoever obeys them
c'		and teaches others to do so
		will be called great in the kingdom of heaven.
	20	For I tell you, unless your righteousness goes beyond that of the experts in the law and the Pharisees, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven!

INDIVIDUALS' TRANSLATIONS

R.T. France	Tim Mackie
17 Do not suppose that I came to abolish the law or the prophets; I did not come to abolish them but to fulfill them. 18 I tell you truly: until heaven and earth pass away, not one small letter or a single stroke of the pen will pass away from the law until everything has taken place. 19 So anyone who sets aside one of these smallest commandments and teaches others to disregard them will be called the smallest in the kingdom of heaven; it is the person who does them and teaches them who will be called great in the kingdom of heaven. 20 For I tell you that that if your righteousness does not go far beyond that of the scribes and Pharisees, you will never get into the kingdom of heaven.	17 Don't suppose that I have come to do away with the Torah (nomos) or the Prophets. I have not come to do away with, but to fill them full (plēroō). 18 Because, truly, I tell you: until the sky and the land pass on, not one dot or one squiggle will pass on from the Torah, until all things have taken place. 19 Therefore, whoever undoes one of the least of these commands, and then they teach people to do this, that person will be called least in the kingdom of the skies. And whoever does [these commands], and then teaches [people to do this], this person will be called great in the kingdom of the skies. 20 Because, truly, I tell you: unless your doing-of-what-is-right far surpasses (perisseuō) that of the Scribes and Phariseaions, you won't be entering into the kingdom of the skies.

COMMENTARY QUOTES

The compactness of 5:17–20 is at once its power and its difficulty. By virtue of its pithy, contrastive statements we get a large-scale snapshot of the issue. But its brevity and super-concentrated collection of weighty terms and ideas mean that every sentence is a spark that sets off a fire in a different direction. Like good poetry, this short passage is thick with meaning and in need of deep reflection.

— Jonathan Pennington, *The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing*, p.171

Matthew is concerned to place Jesus in continuity to the proclamation of the will of God in the Torah and the Prophets, though not merely in the form that Jesus is shown to be in agreement with the Torah and thereby legitimated, but in such a way that Jesus’ teaching first brings to light the content and intention of this proclamation of the will of God in a fully valid manner and thus establishes it. Thus, Jesus does not do and teach the Torah like others before and alongside him. Rather, due to his direct, intimate familiarity with the will of the Father (11.27), he is for Matthew the *one* teacher who has presented (and lived out) the will of God for human beings on the basis of the Torah and the Prophets in a correct, ultimately valid way and with the highest authority...the concern is with the true disclosure in the teaching of Jesus of the will of God that had been proclaimed to Israel in scripture, in the Torah and the Prophets. In other words, Jesus fulfills the Torah and the Prophets by displaying the ‘fullness’ of what is commanded and realizing it in his life.

— Matthias Konradt, *Christology, Torah, and Ethics in the Gospel of Matthew*, pp.77–78

When Paul writes in Gal 6.2 of [the law of Christ], the implied contrast with the traditional phrase, [the law of Moses], proves that, whether or not speculation about a messianic Torah had clearly emerged already in first-century Judaism, at least one Christian could think of Jesus Christ as bringing his own law. Matthew too may have thought in this fashion. This does not, we hasten to add, entail that he recognized the no strain between old and new. He certainly did...Only in so far as the Mosaic law contains concessions to the post-paradisiacal condition will it not directly apply to the eschatological restoration of paradise.

—W.D. Davies & Dale Allison, *The Gospel According to Saint Matthew*, vol. 1, p.493–494

In light of...the tension between vv. 19 and 20, there is a *prima facie* case to be made that Matthew is conscious of two opposite tendencies with which he is concerned, on the one hand a tendency to claim, in line with Paul's "freedom from the law" teaching, that the OT laws no longer matter and can be abandoned, and on the other hand a tendency to emulate the scribes and the Pharisees in careful literal observance of the law as if nothing had changed with the coming of the Messiah...The key to this issue must be what is meant by Jesus "fulfilling" the law and the prophets.

—R.T. France, *The Gospel of Matthew*, p.181

OLD TESTAMENT Psalm 119:89–90, Psalm 102:25-27 (NKJV)

[Relevance: "God's word in the Torah is, by definition, more enduring than what God created by that word (the land and skies)" — Tim Mackie]

Forever, O LORD, Your word is settled in heaven. Your faithfulness endures to all generations;
You established the earth, and it abides.

Of old You laid the foundation of the earth, And the heavens are the work of Your hands.
They will perish, but You will endure; Yes, they will all grow old like a garment;
Like a cloak You will change them, And they will be changed.
But You are the same, And Your years will have no end.

CHALLENGING QUESTIONS

- (v. 17) Why would someone even claim Jesus is trying to abolish the Hebrew scripture with what he has said so far?
- (v. 17) How do you "fulfill" law, in general? Or even Torah specifically?
- (v. 18) How to resolve the double, contradictory "until"s? Until heaven and earth pass away is (presumably) never; until everything takes place is (presumably) an actual time in the future.
- (v. 19) Why is being called "great" in the kingdom of heaven so important; isn't just entering good enough/the whole point? Why is being called "least" supposed to be a deterrent; even in such a scenario aren't I still in heaven?
- (v. 20) What is Jesus talking about when he mentions "righteousness"? The Pharisees seemed pretty focused on (and successful at!) doing what God has said is right; in what way/approach can that be surpassed?
- What is the "correct" relationship that a Christian should have with the Old Testament? Specifically, what is the relevance of OT law to Jesus's audience and us today?

JOURNAL NOTES

¹⁷ Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I have not come to abolish them but to fulfill them. ¹⁸ For truly, I say to you, until heaven and earth pass away, not an iota, not a dot, will pass from the Law until all is accomplished. ¹⁹ Therefore whoever relaxes one of the least of these commandments and teaches others to do the same will be called least in the kingdom of heaven, but whoever does them and teaches them will be called great in the kingdom of heaven. ²⁰ For I tell you, unless your righteousness exceeds that of the scribes and Pharisees, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven. (ESV)